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Aristotle

The Four Causes and the Major Works

A study guide

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Who was Aristotle?

Aristotle (384–322 BCE) was born in Stagira, in northern Greece. At about seventeen he joined Plato’s Academy in Athens, where he studied and taught for roughly two decades. He later tutored the young Alexander of Macedon and, in 335 BCE, founded his own school, the Lyceum, in Athens. He died in Chalcis in 322 BCE.

His surviving writings range across logic, physics, biology, psychology, ethics, politics and the arts. This guide focuses on two things: his **four causes**, a framework for explaining why anything exists or changes, and eight of his **major works**, the treatises through which that thought has reached us.

At a glance

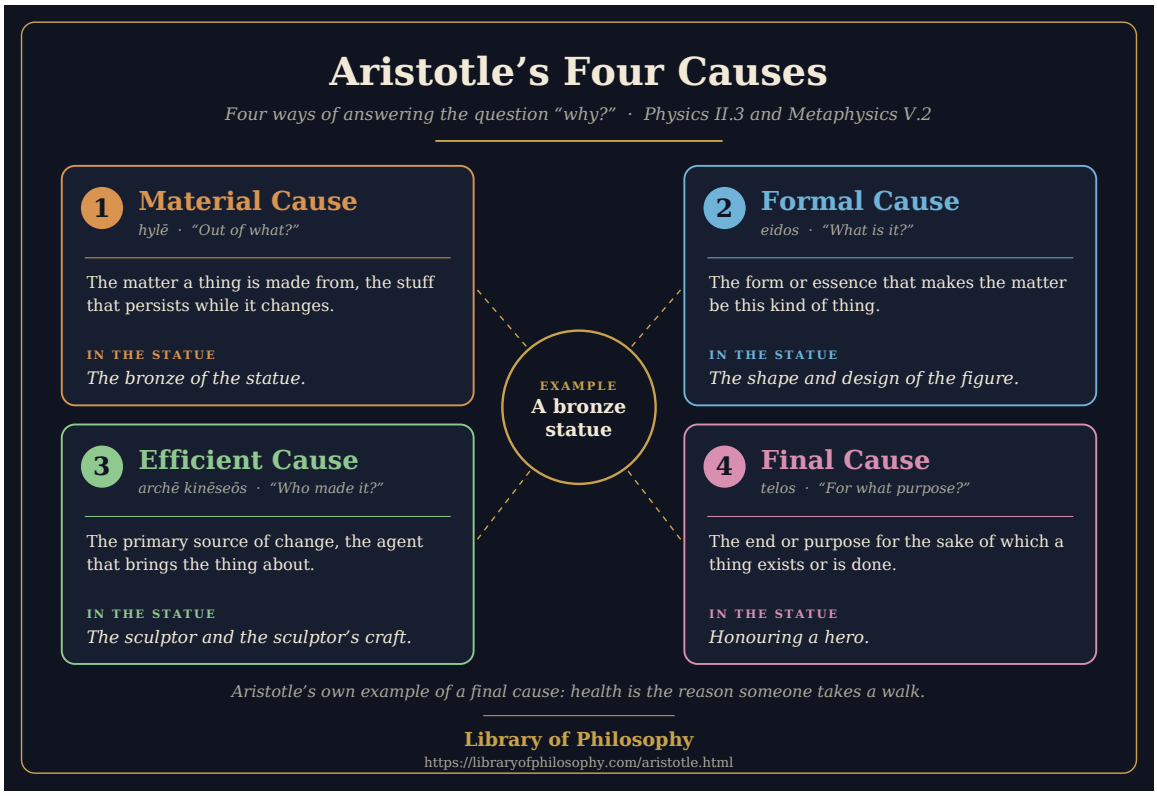
Born	384 BCE, Stagira (northern Greece)
Teacher	Plato, at the Academy in Athens
Pupil	Alexander of Macedon (Alexander the Great)
School	The Lyceum, Athens, founded 335 BCE
Died	322 BCE, Chalcis
In this guide	The Four Causes; The Organon, Physics, De Anima, Metaphysics, Nicomachean Ethics, Politics, Poetics, Rhetoric

How to use this guide

Part I explains the four causes with the diagram and a worked example. Part II maps the major works, with a diagram, a summary table and a short note on each treatise. The last page has a glossary and review questions.

Part I: Aristotle’s Four Causes

For Aristotle, to understand something is to know its *causes* (*aitiai*). The Greek word is closer to “explanatory factors” than to the modern idea of a cause that happens before an effect. He sets out the four in *Physics* II.3 and *Metaphysics* V.2, and argues that a full explanation needs all of them.



1. Material cause (*hylē*)

What a thing is made of. The bronze is the material cause of a statue, and the silver of a bowl. Matter is also what persists through change: the bronze remains bronze whether it is a lump or a figure.

2. Formal cause (*eidos*, *morphē*)

What a thing is: its form, structure or essence. The shape of the figure, and the plan the sculptor holds in mind, make this bronze a statue rather than a heap of metal.

3. Efficient cause (*archē kinēseōs*)

The source from which change begins. The sculptor, working with her craft, is the efficient cause of the statue. This is the sense closest to the modern word “cause”.

4. Final cause (*telos*)

The end, or that for the sake of which something exists or is done. Aristotle’s own example is health as the reason someone takes a walk. For a statue it might be to honour a hero. Final causes are central to his biology and ethics, where living things and human lives are understood by what they are for.

Worked example: four things, four causes

Thing	Material	Formal	Efficient	Final
A statue	Bronze	The shape of the figure	The sculptor	To honour a hero
A house	Bricks and timber	The plan, the design	The builder	Shelter
A walk	Body in motion	Walking as an activity	The walker’s decision	Health
A knife	Steel	A sharp edge, a handle	The smith	Cutting

Part II: Major Works of Aristotle

Most of Aristotle’s surviving works are treatises: lecture-style texts that were edited and arranged long after his death. He divided knowledge into theoretical, practical and productive branches, and treated logic as the tool used by all of them. The diagram groups the eight works accordingly.



The eight works at a glance

Work	Branch	Size	Central question
The Organon	Logic	6 treatises	How can we reason validly and prove things?
Physics	Natural philosophy	8 books	What is nature, and what is change?
De Anima	Natural philosophy	3 books	What is the soul?
Metaphysics	First philosophy	14 books	What is being, and what are the first principles?
Nicomachean Ethics	Practical	10 books	What is the good life?
Politics	Practical	8 books	What is the best way to organise a city?
Poetics	Art	1 treatise	What makes tragedy work?
Rhetoric	Persuasion	3 books	How do speakers persuade?

Notes on each work

The Organon

“Instrument” in Greek. The name was given later to six logical works: *Categories*, *On Interpretation*, *Prior Analytics*, *Posterior Analytics*, *Topics* and *Sophistical Refutations*. Here Aristotle lays out the syllogism and the rules of demonstrative proof, the foundation of logic in the West for many centuries.

Physics

Eight books on nature as a principle of change. It covers the four causes (Book II), place, void, time and the infinite, and ends by arguing that motion needs an unmoved first mover (Book VIII).

De Anima (On the Soul)

Three books on the soul as the form of a living body, not a separate thing. Aristotle distinguishes nutritive, perceptive and rational capacities, and discusses sensation, imagination and intellect.

Metaphysics

Fourteen books on “first philosophy”: being as being, substance, actuality and potentiality, and the highest cause. The title (“after the *Physics*”) comes from later editors, not from Aristotle himself.

Nicomachean Ethics

Ten books asking what the best human life is. Aristotle answers with *eudaimonia* (flourishing), achieved through virtues of character, understood as a mean between extremes, guided by practical wisdom (*phronēsis*).

Politics

Eight books on the *polis*. Aristotle describes humans as political animals, compares constitutions, and asks which forms of government serve the common good and which decay into rule for the few or the many.

Poetics

A short, incomplete treatise on poetry, mainly tragedy and epic. Key ideas are *mimesis* (imitation), the primacy of plot, and *catharsis*, the emotional release tragedy can bring.

Rhetoric

Three books on persuasion. Aristotle names three modes of appeal: *ethos* (the speaker's character), *pathos* (the audience's emotions) and *logos* (the argument itself), and treats rhetoric as a counterpart to dialectic.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
***Aitia* (cause)**	An explanatory factor: one answer to "why?"
Hylē	Matter; the material cause
Eidos, morphē	Form; the formal cause
Telos	End or purpose; the final cause
Eudaimonia	Flourishing, often translated as happiness
Phronēsis	Practical wisdom: good judgment about how to act
Mimesis	Imitation or representation
Catharsis	Emotional release or cleansing, especially through tragedy

Review questions

- Why does Aristotle think that one cause alone cannot fully explain a thing?
- Choose an everyday object and name all four of its causes.
- Which of the four causes is closest to the modern idea of "cause", and why?
- Which works belong to the practical branch, and what do they share?
- What do the *Physics* and the *Metaphysics* have in common, and how do they differ?

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